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Louie Bellson

Drummer and arranger Louie Bellson is one of the most recorded musicians in jazz. He learned piano, percussion and music theory as a youth and won a drum contest sponsored by Gene Krupa at the age of 16. One year later he was playing with Benny Goodman and soon after developed the double bass drum set that has become his trademark. Louis has propelled the big bands of Tommy Dorsey, Count Basie, and Harry James, and enjoyed a long and fruitful association with Duke Ellington, who performed some of the drummer's first arrangements. He was musical director for his wife Pearl Bailey, until the time of her death, and has led his own big bands on both coasts. As a composer, Louis has written numerous big band charts, a jazz ballet, and percussion method books. He is a frequent visitor to college campuses and appears internationally at festivals and jazz concerts. Louis is happily married to Francine Bellson, a physicist and educator, who shares her inspirational message to students, often in tandem with her husband.

Louie was interviewed by Monk Rowe on April 12, 1996 at the Sarasota Jazz Festival.

MR: We are filming today for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive in Sarasota Florida, and it is an extreme, great pleasure to have Louie Bellson with us, drummer extraordinaire and band leader and arranger. Welcome.

LB: Thank you.

MR: You have just about done it all in your career, and you're still doing it, as I just had the pleasure of hearing. How did all this come about? Did you start as a piano player as a child? Did I read that?

LB: Actually no, see I come from a musical family. My father played all the instruments and had a music store, and there were eight of us, four girls, four boys, and all of us worked in the music store. And when I was about three and a half years old, my father took me to a parade, and you know for a little person, three and a half years old, and that drum section comes by you and you know that whole sound envelopes your whole body. So I pointed my little finger and I said "I want to play that." So my dad said I was so definite about it, and he was very liberal-minded as far as wanting to start it at a certain time, it didn't make any difference as long as you had the interest and you wanted to do it, start, you know? So he started me and eventually I had teachers like Roy Knapp in Chicago and then later on it was Murray Spivak in Los Angeles. But in the meantime, by the time I got to be about thirteen years old, he kind of maneuvered me to the piano. Not to play piano as a solo instrument naturally, he just thought it was time for me to learn theory and harmony and composition. And I was against that. But the minute I started and got into it, then I realized that yeah, I like this, because there's something inside of me that says

compose and arrange, and you can always play drums. So that's what I did. I kept studying hard with my father and then later on when I got on the road I had Buddy Baker, who just retired from Disney Studios as one of their great composers. I started with him in 1947, and he's still my teacher. We do things like decipher Ravel's "Daphnis et Chloé" bar by bar you know. But it's a never ending process you know. You just keep on learning, and that's the exciting thing about music.

MR: Well the piano was a good idea then.

LB: Yeah it was. Because my father said, you know, it's all right to play percussion and play drums, that's wonderful, but some day, if you're a band leader, you'll have respect for your men more if you rehearse the band, don't have somebody else rehearse it. You get out there in front and say well let's see that's a G minor seventh chord and somebody's playing a B natural instead of a B flat. And so he was right.

MR: Oh — a drummer knows that, yes.

LB: Well a lot of the young drummers, well some of the older guys like Tiny Kahn was a great orchestrator, great arranger. And today, Billy Cobham, Steve Gadd, Tony Williams, a lot of these guys are composing and writing, and Harvey Mason, drummers like that you know, not only great percussion players but they're very sensitive as to what the music is all about.

MR: And when was it that you really felt that you could become a professional musician?

LB: Well I was very fortunate, they allowed me to join the union in Moline, Illinois when I was fourteen years old. However, in order to play the gigs at that time, you had to play in a little beer joint you know, I had to be accompanied by a grown up. They had to get me there, help me set up the drums and sit there and make sure I didn't indulge in alcohol, and played the gig, and then he got me back home. But that was great experience because one of the greatest things that happened to me on every Tuesday night in Moline there was a night club called The Rendezvous. And Spec Red, the great piano player from DesMoines Iowa, had a drummer and a bass player and a saxophone player from Kansas City, a wonderful quartet. And they allowed me to come in and sit in and play with them all night on Tuesday. Now that's where you really learn how to swing. Because when you play with a quartet like that, in front of a live audience, on stage, with other instrument players, then you really know about when to use this cymbal, this cymbal, how to use the brushes, be sensitive to backing up the soloists, and that really set me up. So by the time I was seventeen years old, I was ready to go on the road.

MR: That was a perfect education at that point in your career then.

LB: It was. Because school is wonderful. The schooling is very, very important. Education in music and academic education is marvelous. But you also have to get that training of going in and playing on the stage with other players. Then you have to go out and, what

we used to call "get your feet wet." Time on a bus, and do some one-nighters, play in ballrooms, play in theaters, play in night clubs, and that's where you get the feel of the real music you know.

MR: Well you went through a real succession of great big bands and you must have been popular, because you hit them all.

LB: I was very fortunate. Back home, when I was fourteen, fifteen, sixteen years old, there used to be a couple of places, one in Moline and one in Davenport, where all the big bands came to play the big ballrooms. The Coliseum in Davenport in particular, and every time a band like Ted Weems or Harry James or Ted Fio Rito, I'm naming some of the old guys now, all the kids would say "hey, let Louie play the drums" you know. So the band leader would always say "yeah, okay, where is he?" And I'd get up and I'd play you know. So when I got up to play for Ted Fio Rito, he offered me a job right there. And I said "well Ted, I've got like three or four more months in high school and I want to get my diploma. I wanted to go to college, but if you offer me a gig and some money, maybe I'll change my mind. But I want to graduate from high school." So he waited, and he kept his word. His drummer was leaving anyway. And the first gig was to fly out to Los Angeles from Moline, Illinois, and play the Florentine Gardens on Hollywood Boulevard, which are beautiful, big — they don't have places like that anymore —where they had a line of girls there, they had the Mills Brothers were the main attraction, Ted Fio Rito's Big Band, Dr. Giovanni's Pickpocket, famous pickpocket you know, and a tremendous big show. I was there for three months in that place, and while I was there, Freddy Goodman, Benny Goodman's brother just happened to wander in and take in the show, and they liked the way I played, and sent a note over to me and I went over to the table and he said "you know Benny Goodman is out here making a picture, a motion picture, and he's looking for a drummer."

MR: You were what, seventeen or something?

LB: I started to freeze up, I'm thinking here Ted got me all the way from home and I'd just been with him three months, now I get the offer to go with the King of Swing. So my audition was not really an audition. I didn't go somewhere in a room or play for Benny. All he did was tell Freddy take him in, put a tuxedo on him, put the make up on him and I'll see him on the set. So we played one small band tune on the set, the motion picture. After we played the tune Benny said "okay kid, we leave Thursday for New York."

MR: Amazing.

LB: I didn't have a chance to say wa-wa-wa wait a minute, hold it, you know. Hold it. So he just said "I'll see you Thursday." So Freddy said "well, you got the job." Now what am I going to say to Ted Fio Rito? I told all the guys in the band. They said "look, Ted'll be angry at first, but you go ahead and we'll explain to him later on what the situation was."

And that's what happened. I saw him months and months later and he says that was great, but however, I thought maybe you'd stay with me a little longer. But it was a great experience joining Benny's band.

MR: And this was what year?

LB: That had to be around '42, '42 I think, 1942, yeah.

MR: Amazing. And you probably toured around the country quite a bit with him?

LB: Yeah I did just under a year with Benny and then Uncle Sam got me. But I was very fortunate. They looked at my credentials, having worked with Benny Goodman. I was supposed to go to March Field with Ziggy Elman's band in California. Instead they shipped me to Washington, D.C. with an excellent band, a big orchestra, a concert band, a marching band, a big jazz band, small combos, so I actually did a lot of playing when I was in the service for three years. And we were stationed at Walter Reed Hospital and we had to play for all those amputees who came back from the war. And the best medicine they could have was to hear American jazz — or any kind of music — it could be symphonic music, chamber music, whatever. And I played more drum solos for those guys than I ever did back in civilian life. So that was a nice experience. Three years for Uncle Sam, and then when I got out, I went back with Ted Fio Rito for about, oh maybe three or four months again, and then back with Benny Goodman.

MR: No kidding?

LB: That had to be in '46.

MR: Did you give him like a week's notice this time when you left?

LB: Yeah, I gave him proper notice this time, yeah. I played it straight this time. And after that, Benny was kind of semi-retired then. He was going to go back to New York and not do too much, so that left an opening for me to join Tommy Dorsey in 1947. And that was a great experience, a wonderful band. He had people in there like Charlie Shavers the great trumpet player, Ziggy Elman was still in the band then, Paul Smith on piano, and Tommy himself was just superb you know. I stayed with him for three years, and then joined Harry James for one year out in California. I wanted to go to California to study with Buddy Baker, who is presently my composition teacher. And the one year with Harry was great. Well in that band they had Willie Smith playing lead alto and Juan Tizol, the great valve trombonist who used to be with Duke. And I stayed at Juan Tizol's house. So Juan said "I've got to talk to you and Willie because I just talked to Duke Ellington today." I said "really?" He said "yeah." He said "he's looking for a lead alto player, Johnny Hodges is leaving, and he's also looking for a drummer." So now what do we say to Harry James? So all three of us went to Harry James and we said "Harry—" Of course we had an out with Harry because he wasn't working every night. He was working like Fridays and Saturdays and that's about it, just weekends. We said "Harry" all three

of us said "we have a chance to join Duke Ellington's band." So he looked at us and hesitated for about fifteen seconds, then he said "take me with you." I'll never forget those words you know. But he was a great man. Harry was a great player and a sensational band besides you know. But I did get a chance to work with him for a while. And then of course after that, of course with Ellington, there are so many stories about that band, and Ellington himself was an element of surprise, always. Because you never knew exactly what monumental piece of music he was doing for a certain occasion that other bands didn't do. You know, besides the ballrooms and the theaters and television coming in, we were in on the first Sacred Concert that was done in Grace Cathedral in San Francisco. So just to be a part of that was something. You know I look back at that as really an experience, you know?

MR: People talk about the difference in discipline and way to lead the band between certain guys like Benny Goodman and Ellington I guess had his own way of dealing with his personnel.

LB: Oh yes. All those band leaders had a different way. But the great thing about Basie and Ellington, when you analyze their situation, they were both rhythm section players, piano players. And when they beat off a band, unless they were doing something in television where they had to give a down beat or something like that, but normal playing swing, they played with the rhythm for one, maybe two choruses, until that groove settled in. Then, by the time the band came in, there was no question where the time was. Rather than give a one-two, one-two-three-four. Sometimes that's a little offhand to try to capture that tempo right off the bat. You have to have a strong rhythm section to lock it in right away see? But with them, being rhythm section players, that made a great difference. And that's why it was such a joy to work for them, because they established, and they were both so tempo conscious, but they had a natural flair for knowing exactly what tempo for this tune, what tempo for that tune. They were masters for that.

MR: Something to learn from Basie. Getting back to Ellington for a moment, did you get a chance to see Ellington and Strayhorn, how they collaborated on their music? It seems like such a fascinating thing the way they pulled that off.

LB: Well you know Ellington — I mean Strayhorn joined Ellington as a lyricist and from what I hear and Billy Strayhorn told me that I don't think that Duke knew at first that he arranged as a lyricist. So Duke gave Strayhorn an assignment for lyrics, and he said "I'll check you out when I get back, we've got to go to Europe." So when they came back from Europe, Billy said "I write arrangements also." So Duke said "really?" He said "do you have one?" He said "yeah." And that was "Take the A Train." And I think Strayhorn told me that Duke put his arm around him and said "you're with me forever."

MR: Wow.

LB: But you know that was a perfect match. Because nobody in that band, even the guys that had been there for years like Harry Carney, they couldn't tell the difference, whether Strayhorn wrote the composition or whether Duke did it. That's how close it was.

MR: Amazing.

LB: They were an exceptional twosome. I would say they were both geniuses, really. Very superstitious. Don't ever whistle in the dressing room; Duke and Strayhorn never put a button, a finé on an arrangement. They got down to letter S and then just let it fizzle out, then they worked it out at the rehearsal, but never really put like boom, the finale there.

MR: They didn't write it you mean?

LB: They didn't write it. They worked it out at rehearsal, see? And never wore a shirt with buttons all the way down, there was only maybe three buttons this way and then the slipover, and no color yellow, but blue was the favorite color. And I made the mistake once of giving him a gift for his birthday, a pair of bedroom shoes, he says "no, no, no, no, no, don't do that, don't do that. That means you're going to be walking out of my life."

MR: No kidding?

LB: I said "oh really?" And so I exchanged those for a blue sweater. But they both had that great originality that you look for, that you strive for, and it came natural for them. You know Ellington never really went to school to learn how to write music. And Strayhorn may have had a little bit, but they had that God-given talent to be able to sit down and write music but it was strictly their style. They weren't getting it from somebody else. It was, there it was. In the voicing in the reed section, the voicings in the brass section, being able to supply the soloists. He knew every soloist, what their range was, so when he wrote something for you, it was perfect, just like you getting a brand new set of clothes and they fit perfect. And he gave you the greatest introductions in the world. He really set you up you know. One thing, when I joined the band, Strayhorn and I roomed together for about almost three weeks. And I made the mistake of telling Strayhorn one night, we were just talking and I said "Strayhorn, how did Duke voice that 'Caravan?' thing? Boy, man, I could really see the camels coming when they play that one part." And he went like this to me "ahhh." And I said "oh, excuse me, I'm invading your privacy." So I didn't say a word, and I guess Strayhorn had talked to Duke about me asking and so forth, and nothing happened for about oh, three or four months, and all of a sudden we were doing a one-nighter and Duke got up on the piano, this was before the people came in, and he said "come here" to me "sit down by the piano." He explained to me how he voiced "Caravan." What notes he gave to Johnny Hodges, what notes he gave to Procope, Carney, and so forth. "This is what I did." So I thought to myself man, here

the great Duke Ellington is taking time out to show me some voicings. Other band leaders have been striving, trying to figure out what did he do there, how did he voice that.

MR: What's that, I just read a quote from Andre Previn, who said a thousand musicians can get together and play a chord that Stan Kenton wrote and all the arrangers know how to do that. And Duke Ellington writes something for three instruments and they play it and I don't know what it is.

LB: Well in harmony and in theory it's really much easier to write for four voices or five voices. But to write for three voices and two voices, because he had three trombone players, and those three trombone players sounded like five or six of them sometimes. But I found after working with the band I discovered in a very short time that you could have Ellington's band play an arrangement, and then have another choice band, maybe like a New York band or an L.A. band, all great musicians, playing the same chart, but the difference, the air that they're putting in their horns, Carney, Willie Smith, Johnny Hodges, Paul Gonsalves, Jimmy Hamilton, Clark Terry, Juan Tizol, Lawrence Brown, Tricky Sam. This is something that you can't explain, but the way they played it, the way they made it sound, that was it.

MR: Didn't they play some of your first charts?

LB: When I joined the band, Tizol was telling Duke, "yeah this kid, he knows how to write, too." He said "well tell him to bring an arrangement in." I said "Tizol, no way, I'm not going to do that, not with him and Strayhorn around." I was being just this high you know. So he had to ask me two or three times. So finally Tizol got a hold of "Hawk Talks" and "Skin Deep" and when Duke heard "Hawk Talks" they recorded it right off the bat.

MR: What a thrill.

LB: I was just, you know, as a kid I couldn't get over it. And it enjoyed some success as a jazz cut you know. And then later on we couldn't find a studio in those days to record "Skin Deep," because all that drumming, they couldn't find a studio to get the clarity of all those fast beats that I was doing on "Skin Deep." So Duke hesitated. He said "let's wait on that one." So while we were on the road, Burt Porter, who was one of the guys that brought in the Ampex hi-fi, he recorded the band one night in Fresno, California. And when Duke heard that, he said "okay, let's record 'Skin Deep.'" So we did that out on the coast, and then sent that tape into Columbia. And they wanted to know where we did that, because they said we couldn't do anything like that you know. So if you study that cut real closely you'll discover that "Skin Deep" sounded very different than the other things on that album. And that's the reason why.

MR: So it was recorded not in the studio, or was it recorded on location or something?

LB: We had finished playing Fresno, that's when we heard the recorded tape that Burt did, and we were on our way up to Seattle. Somewhere in there we played a ballroom and Duke liked the sound of the ballroom so he said "okay, let's go down after the gig and do 'Skin Deep.'" We did, and we lucked out.

MR: And this was in the '50's?

LB: Yeah. '51. 1951 I joined the band. Shortly after that we recorded "Hawk Talks" and "Skin Deep." Yeah.

MR: Was there ever any problem in certain parts of the country with any racial subjects coming up?

LB: Well yes, we did have. In 1951 they had the Big Show of 1951, which consisted of Nat King Cole, Sarah Vaughan and Duke Ellington's band. They were the three big stars. Now besides that they had Peg Leg Bates, Timmy Rodgers, Stump and Stumpy, Patterson and Jackson, all these wonderful acts — tap dancing acts, you know. It took us a week to rehearse that whole show, playing with Nat King Cole and Sarah, Duke, and all these acts. So after we finished rehearsing for a week, Duke finally discovered that hey, we're getting ready to go down to the deep south you know? And in those days, you had segregated audiences. And we couldn't, the whites couldn't play with the blacks at that time you see. And in those days it was "colored," you didn't use the word "blacks" see? So now the big problem is, Duke called me in the dressing room and says "what are we going to do? I can't find a drummer to take your place, because it would be a week's rehearsal and the guys that can do it, they're all busy." So Duke says "you mind being a Haitian?" I said "no, okay, that's all right" you know. So we got through it okay. It was a little tense, because the situation was still down there, and the audience, because they told Jack Costanzo with Nat King Cole he couldn't appear because of the racial thing you know. But some spots it was a little rough you know. But we got through it. I think through Ellington's peaceful ways and the wonderful attitude that the band had you know, kind of rubbed off on everybody. But still it existed.

MR: Well it's nice that the music had a part in helping that situation to move along a little faster I guess.

LB: Well you know we played a gig in Mississippi and there the townspeople were wonderful, they came to the rescue, where we couldn't stay in certain hotels and so forth. I mean these people came from wealthy families too. They had Strayhorn and Duke and Clark Terry stay in one house, and Carney and Russell Procope and myself in another house, and all on down the line. Beautiful homes and they fed us. So you know, along with the bad there's some good too you know. And these were situations that we got over, we dealt with it. Sometimes it's almost like a slap in the face but you realize what the situation is and you go straight ahead because you've got something to do that's

valued and I think when you do that you realize that none of those things should bother the musicality of something. It's the fact that whoever's playing that music doesn't make a difference, let's play it and show where the peace and love is.

MR: I read some funny story about — did you room with Charlie Shavers for a while?

LB: We were roommates for three years in Tommy Dorsey's band. There was another giant. Great trumpet player, great arranger, great composer — he wrote "Undecided" and all those wonderful things with the John Kirby small group. I learned a lot rooming with Charlie. He taught me a lot about music, taught me some tap dance steps. Of course when you played the theater in those days, you'd did everything. You'd learn how to be an emcee, you'd learn how to get up and tell some jokes, and do a little shim sham shimmy and a time step, as well as play your instrument you know.

MR: Did he used to fall asleep in the tub or something like that?

LB: Yeah.

MR: It was something I read in one of these jazz books and I just felt I had to ask you about that.

LB: Yeah. Well my two main teachers were Big Sid Catlett and Jo Jones. I had a chance to see Chick [Webb] once but Big Sid and Jo really called me aside and said "look, here's how you play the brushes, here's how you do this, here's how you do this, and always remember, don't ever lose one." You know I learned that from Dizzy too. What they meant was when you play a four bar break, make sure everybody knows where one is. Because once you lose one, two three and four is gone and it never comes back.

MR: Right.

LB: So one is very important.

MR: Well what was your first association with Count Basie?

LB: The first time with Basie? Let me see. It was actually when I joined Norman Granz, Jazz at the Philharmonic. I had known Basie before that because in 1951 he'd been appearing in New York at the Strand Theater and we were at Birdland, right across the street. And he used to come down and his own words were "I went straight to the bar and put my head down and with my hands around my head, and just listened to you guys, and getting madder and madder as I heard all of this great music coming out of that band." You know because he was a real Ellington fan. And vice versa, Ellington was a big Basie fan. But I really started recording some small group things with Norman Granz, with the trumpet kings and I was in on the two piano things with Oscar Peterson and Basie. That was a great experience. And then I forget what year, in the '60's I was to go into Birdland with my small group, and Basie was going on a very important tour in Sweden for over a month. And Sonny Payne got very ill. So Basie said "can you do me a great favor?" I said "anything you ask." So we went to Morris Levy, who owns Birdland. He said "okay,

we'll fix it out Lou, I'll take care of your guys and you can play the gig when you get back." So I did about five weeks with that band and recorded with them. And that was like Ellington's band, just a tremendous experience. I was talking to Frank Wess about that today because he was on the band, and also Benny Powell. And Basie during that time was trying to straighten himself out, not too much alcohol. And he knew that I didn't drink and I had some goodies in my bag at all times to munch on. Because over there in Europe after eleven o'clock, everything closes — nothing — unless you know of a special place. So I stocked up, I got my sardines together and apple juice and crackers and everything and after the gig there'd be a knock on my door — bamm, bamm, bamm, bamm. I'd say "who is it?" "Me, Basie." Now you can imagine, me sitting with Basie, every night, for about four or five hours, eating these little goodies and talking about life.

MR: Oh, man.

LB: That experience was just — between him and Ellington it was something that if anybody had just one day with either one of them it would be a blessing. We laughed, he was a very funny man you know, and could really be deep also. And his psychology was very simple but so direct, so right you know. Just the way he played.

MR: I was just going to say—

LB: Plink, plink, plink. It was beautiful.

MR: You got to work with him in different configurations: the Kansas City Six and the Seven and a lot of great albums.

LB: Right. And then they issued — while I was in Europe with him we recorded four or five straight days in Copenhagen at the Tivoli Gardens. And that came out on Mosaic Records, all live Basie, Live from Birdland with Sonny Payne, and different drummers, and then the four days in Copenhagen. And man it sounded so great. And I had a kick out of listening to myself and listening to that band.

MR: When was your first attempt at putting your own band together? When did that come about?

LB: Well during my time with Ellington, before that, when I stayed at Tizol's house, they always used to tell me about Pearl, Pearl Bailey. Because she was good friends with the Tizols and she occupied a room in the house also. And I heard, I said "yes, I've heard of her," you know. They said "well you two must meet." So we finally met in D.C. at the Howard Theater. And that was in '51. And after four days, after I met her four days we decided to get married. And that's, we got married in London, mainly because that band never took a vacation en masse. There was always two or three guys at a time, but the band kept going. So my turn was up and Pearl happened to be in London so I flew over there and we got married over there. That was a wonderful experience. She was a great lady, great performer for 38, almost 39 years, and I felt that when she passed away, which

was a big shock to all of us, you know I thought well I'm going to play my drums and no more, just straight ahead and here I get another blessing. Three and a half years ago I met Francine on a wonderful cruise that you fly up to Vancouver and come back on the cruise you know, with Leonard Feather and all the Ellington guys on there. And I met her the last two days of the trip you know, and we hit it off and here I am again after three and a half years. But she's a physicist. She's an engineer.

MR: And now I can ask you about your shirt.

LB: Yeah, that's right. Well she's a —

MR: Can we zero in on the shirt?

LB: She's a graduate of MIT and Harvard. And she worked for IBM for about fourteen years and she's a marvelous educator. And we take a lot of pride in going into schools now and doing lectures. She'll talk about education and her life as a physicist and then turn it over to me and I talk about Ellington and Basie, and if there's a set of drums there and a bass player or a piano player then I do a little bit there and we have fun doing that and the kids love that.

MR: I'll bet.

LB: Because they get a duo thing going there you know. We do this besides me doing a clinic for the drummers and a then doing a concert at night with the band and so forth. So, lot of fun.

MR: Well you've been able to employ some pretty hot sidemen with your own band, in addition to your own arranging, you've had some great contributions from people. Don Menza you mentioned—

LB: Don Menza, a marvelous, a great player. He's borderline genius too, he really is. He's something else. He's a great player. Pete Christlieb, another sax player, Ricky Woodard now just joined us, and he's another great saxophone player. I got Conte Condoli playing with us and his brother, and oh just Carl Fontana works with us now and then, Frank Strazzeri on piano, John Heard on bass. And now I have three bands you know. I have my New York band, a Chicago band and an L.A. band. Because if I get a gig in New York, I can't fly all those guys in so I've got a set of drums there and a library so all we need to do is say "let's go" and we're ready. I get all the good players. Because they love to play, they like to play.

MR: Yeah, sure do. I recently heard the Slide Hampton Big Band in New York and the way they have some adventuresome writing there.

LB: Yeah. It's great.

MR: How did, I meant to ask this earlier on, but how did the double bass drum set come to fruition?

LB: Well Eddie Shaughnessy came to me once and he said "hey, did you really start the two bass drums? I thought you did, but did Ray McKinley do it first?" I said well I don't know because when I was a youngster in 1938 I drew the plans for the double bass drum kit. And around 1940, I saw in *Down Beat* where Ray McKinley was teamed with Will Bradley. They had a band together. They did a lot of boogie woogie things. And there was a picture of him with just two bass drums, see? And so when I saw Ray after that I said "Ray, were you the first one to do that?" He said "no, you were the first one." So you know we were playing gentleman games there you know. But I think Ray said it, he said "well if you drew the plans in '38 then you're the first one." Because what I did, I just did a thing with just the two bass drums, but you came out with a whole set, the whole thing, see? So the players that followed me on that were Eddie Shaughnessy and the Sam Woodyard, Billy Cobham, and quite a few drummers after that you know. But I got that idea because having been some kind of a so-called tap dancer years ago, this side of the body was as strong as this side. And I always wanted to get a drum sound over here, not only the high hat but another drum sound. So I figured well I can put both pedals over here and I'll have the dual sound with the bass drums and still have the high hat and still have the snare drum and a tom tom and the cymbals here. So that was the general idea. Solo-wise there's no limit to what you can do. In the band, playing sambas and everything, you can get a lot of interesting sounds and also set-ups for the band. But there were some times when I didn't use that bass drum at all. A lot of times I used it, but I had to use my musicality and my taste, to make sure it's done the right way you know. But it proved to be standardized equipment now. A lot of people are using it. A lot of these youngsters are playing it too, I mean they've really got a technique and the feel and everything.

MR: It must have helped to be a tap dancer I would think.

LB: Yeah.

MR: Have you ever had occasion to play with Joe Williams?

LB: Joe Williams? Absolutely. There is an example, well he's such a great talent, but what makes Joe Williams so great, is not only is he one of the greatest singers in the world, but when he comes in to rehearse, he comes in like a gentleman, he knows exactly what he wants to rehearse, what he wants to work out, he does it, he's in and out with no problems. That to me is a real artist you know? Because he knows exactly what the band should sound like, what the dynamic should be, what he wants from the drummer, and he does it in a relationship like a love relationship. "Here, let's all work together and get this thing going." He does it, in and out. I love working with him. Tony Bennett is another guy like that. Basie was the same way, Ellington. Those kind of performers, they know exactly what they want to do. Johnny Carson on "The Tonight Show" always told me he

never had trouble with the biggies. Ella Fitzgerald would come on the show, Joe Williams, Tony Bennett, Duke, whoever it was, Dizzy. In and out. It was always that person that didn't quite make it that — "something is wrong with the dressing room."

MR: Starts demanding things.

LB: "I don't have room in the dressing room" — something — "the band's too loud." And of course that's the last time you saw them on the show.

MR: Oh my. Did you once record something with Basie called "The Happiest Millionaire" or something? Can you recall that?

LB: I think I did that.

MR: And it was some sound you used with some drum sticks or something.

LB: Yeah. I used jingle sticks.

MR: Jingle sticks.

LB: What I did quite a few years ago, I took the jingles off the tambourine and put them on the drum stick. And Basie used to call them bells. "I like those bells — give me those bells" you know he loved that sound. I designed them strictly for maybe bossa novas and Latin things. But then I found out later on it's good for certain swing things too. And Basie loved it. It was a nice sound, a different sound, yeah.

MR: What's in the immediate future? I know you're playing tonight, which I'm looking forward to, but where do you go from here?

LB: From here we go back to San Jose, Francine and I live in San Jose part of the time and part of the time down in Sherman Oaks, that's near L.A. And we're home for two days in San Jose and then we're off to Michigan, Ypsilanti, Michigan. I'm playing with a college band there, a big jazz band, and I'm doing a piece written for me with a percussion ensemble. So I'm doing two things and then also a clinic for all the drummers. And then from there we come back home, and go down to L.A. and we get ready to go to Montana to play a gig up there, and then we get ready to go to Berne, Switzerland with a New York band, a whole band, and we're backing up Manhattan Transfer on three of those concerts, and one alone with the band, and Clark Terry and Milt Hinton also, if he's up to it, will be our guests with our band. So we've got a lot of exciting things going.

MR: Oh, you gentlemen do get around, I'll tell you.

LB: We keep on going. My wife keeps saying "when are we going home? When are we going home?"

MR: I'm sure you've been around the world a number of times.

LB: Well just about. I haven't been to China yet or South America. I had the occasion to go to both places but I was always busy here in the States. But some day I'll make that, and then pretty much so, I'll have all territory.

MR: You've got it covered.

LB: But you know it's great fun when you're doing something that you really love to do, it's a lot of fun, and as long as I can keep doing it I'll be hitting rim shots and crashing cymbals. Oh yeah, I got a new CD now that was just released on Concord, and I've always wanted to do this, it's a salute honoring twelve great drummers, most of them from the back era and some are in the present state, and a few that are still living, like starting with Chick Webb, Big Sid Catlett, Jo Jones, Buddy, Gene, Elvin Jones, Tony Williams, Shelly Manne and Steve Gadd are the new guys and Dennis Chambers. And it's not so much drum solos, but the caption on the album is "their time was the greatest." It's sort of like groovin' what they did in the band, so there's a lot of wonderful big band. And eventually they're going to put another CD out without me, so that the student can put the headset on and have the drum parts, and play along with that band.

MR: Oh, boy, that's quite a project, to try to capture all the —

LB: The album is out now and the disc jockeys are really enjoying playing it. The band is really superb. Their performance went exceptionally well.

MR: Great. Looking forward to getting that for the college, and we should have you at Hamilton sometime.

LB: Sure.

MR: Maybe after the China trip.

LB: Okay, that's good.

MR: Let us know.

LB: That's great.

MR: Well this has really been fascinating and thanks for fitting us in to what's been a busy day here in Sarasota.

LB: Well thank you. I always say when you want to talk about one of my favorite subjects which is music, I can go on and on and on, and having a lot of fun. And by the way, now I have the luxury of saying that they have a festival named after me, in Moline, Rock Island and Davenport. And they have it around May every year. This is the third one coming up, ours is May the 19th this year, and Clark Terry was in on the second one. He did such a great job he's coming back for the third one. And we do it with a local band there and we're starting to pull in different people and it looks like we're getting the proper backing and we're having a lot of fun with that.

MR: That's good news. Well thanks so much on behalf of Hamilton College. I want to thank Louie Bellson for a great hour of conversation.

LB: Thank you, my pleasure.